COURSE :- LANGUAGE & LINGUISTICS

TOPIC :- LANGUAGE UNIVERSALS

- Joseph Greenberg:- pioneer of the concept

- **Empirical approach**: Greenberg looked at real-world data from 30 languages instead of building abstract rules.
- **Implicational patterns**: Many rules use an "if-then" format, showing how one feature predicts another.
- **Strong tendencies**: Most rules describe common patterns rather than strict absolute laws.

- A **linguistic universal** is a pattern that occurs systematically across natural languages, potentially true for all of them.

Importance of studying language universals

• Reveals the “psychic unity of mankind” — the shared basic propensities and abilities of all human populations.

• Helps identify the most fundamental aspects of human beings in their social environment and sheds light on the earliest stages of human culture.

• Demonstrates that language, as both a cultural system and a symbolic reflection of culture, rests on universal structural and conceptual foundations.

• Supports the view that language is an immensely ancient human heritage, older than most material culture, and illuminates problems of cultural prehistory.

• Has practical value for international communication:
– Guides the selection of core vocabulary for foreign-language teaching.
– Provides the essential conceptual core for designing artificial international languages.
– Improves translation by distinguishing easily transferable universal ideas from culture-specific ones that need elaboration or adaptation.

EXPLANATIONS FOR EXISTENCE OF LANGUAGE UNIVERSALS

- **Universal Grammar**

Hardwired biology: Noam Chomsky proposed that humans are born with an innate, genetically determined biological framework for language.
Poverty of the stimulus: Children learn complex language structures rapidly despite not receiving enough detailed negative feedback or exposure to learn every rule from scratch.
Shared constraints: These innate brain structures place strict boundaries on what shapes a human grammar can take.

- **Cognitive and Processing Efficiency**

Brain limitations: Human memory and processing capacities face shared operational limits.
Optimized communication: Studies suggest efficient brains favour simple, organized structures such as placing certain modifiers or core arguments in predictable patterns—to reduce the energy required to encode and decode meaning.
Conceptual mapping: Basic linguistic divisions, like nouns and verbs, mirror how the human mind universally separates physical objects from dynamic events.

- **Shared Evolutionary and Functional Pressures**

Adaptation for interaction: All human languages serve the same practical purpose: social cooperation, sharing information, and expressing complex thoughts.

Common history or design: Certain communication strategies proved vastly superior for survival and cultural transmission, leading recurring patterns to propagate across unrelated populations over generations.

TYPES OF LANGUAGE UNIVERSALS

- **Formal vs Substantive Universals**

Substantive universals refer to the actual building blocks and content elements found in all human languages. The fundamental vocabulary, categories, and inventory of features that make up the substance of a language.
Example**:** Lexical and syntactic categories like nouns and verbs, phonetic features like vowels and consonants, or semantic roles like agent and patient.

Formal universals refer to the structural rules, organization, and constraints that govern how a language operates. They are the operational laws of grammar rather than the specific content.
Example: Principles of phrase-structure organization (like X-bar theory), transformational rules, and constraints on how rules interact.

Implicational vs Non-Implicational Universals

An implicational universal is structured as a conditional ("if-then") rule that links the presence of one linguistic property to the mandatory or statistical presence of another. A statement of the form "if a language has feature X, it will also have feature Y“ or feature Y relies on the prior existence of feature X within that language's system.
Example: If a language uses a strict Subject-Object-Verb (SOV) word order, it tends to use postpositions rather than prepositions.

A non-implicational universal states that a specific linguistic feature exists (or does not exist) in all or most languages independently of any other property. It is an unconditional statement about human language.
Example: All human languages possess distinct open-class lexical categories like nouns and verbs to name objects and describe actions.
Every known spoken language utilizes a combination of vowel and consonant sounds.
All languages contain personal pronouns to refer to speech participants.

Absolute Universals vs Tendencies

An Absolute Universal is a structural feature or rule that has zero exceptions across all human languages. They are very rare. They point to core, unyielding properties of the human language faculty.
Example: All languages have pronouns.
All languages distinguish vowels and consonants.
All languages have nouns and verbs.

Tendencies are patterns that occurs with overwhelming frequency across the world's languages, but can have rare exceptions. They happen because of common human habits or brain functions, not strict laws. They show what languages *prefer* to do, even if other choices are possible.
Example: The vast majority of languages use nasal sounds like /m/ and /n/, though a tiny number might lack them.
Most languages place the subject before the object (such as SVO or SOV order), even though rare languages use other orders.

Greenberg's Universals 1-7 (Word Order Universals)

1. In declarative sentences with nominal subject and object, the dominant order is [almost always] one in which the subject precedes the object.
The three common basic orders are SVO, SOV, and VSO; orders with object before subject (OSV, OVS, VOS) are very rare.
Examples: English (SVO): "The dog chased the cat." Dog=Subj ; Cat=Obj
Hindi (SOV): "कुत्ता बिल्ली को पीछा करता है।" कुत्ता-Subj ; बिल्ली-Obj

2. In language with prepositions, the genitive [almost always] follows the governing noun while in languages with postpositions it [almost always] precedes.
English (SVO): "The book of Harry Potter is interesting."
Book- governing noun ; of- genitive ; Harry Potter- qualifying noun
Hindi (SOV): "राम का बेटा अच्छा है।"
राम- qualifying noun ; का-genitive ; बेटा- governing noun
Here, the Genitive always precedes the Governing Noun or the Genitive follows the Qualifying Noun.

3. Languages with dominant VSO order are always prepositional.
Example: Arabic (VSO)- Fī al-bayti – "in the-house" Fī / in - preposition

4. With overwhelmingly greater than chance frequency, languages with normal SOV order are postpositional.
Example: Hindi (SOV)- “किताब मेज़ पर है।” किताब- Subj ; मेज़- Obj ; पर- postposition

5. If a language has dominant SOV order and the genitive follows the governing noun, then the adjective likewise follows the noun.
Example: Hindi (SOV)- सुबह-ए-बनारस , दीवान-ए-आम ए- genitive

6. All languages with dominant VSO order have SVO as an alternative basic or as the only alternative basic order.
Example: Arabic (VSO dominant) ʔakala al-kalb-u al-qiṭṭ-a (Alternate SVO) al-kalb-u ʔakala al-qiṭṭ-a
ate. the-dog. the-cat. the-dog. ate. the-cat.
‘The dog ate the cat.’ ‘The dog ate the cat.’

7. If in a language with dominant SOV order, there is no alternative basic order, or only OSV as the alternative, then all adverbial modifiers of the verb likewise precede the verb.
Example: Hindi (SOV)- “ राम आम धीरे धीरे खाता है।”
राम- Subj ; आम-